SMALL-GROUP GUIDE

The Man Who Pulled Down the House

Samson · Judges 16:4–31

Text: Judges 16:4–31 (with Judges 13–15; Hebrews 11:32; John 2:18–22; 2 Corinthians 12:9–10) **Big idea:** Samson pulled down Dagon's house with his own hands and died in the rubble; Jesus let his own house be pulled down and rose from it. **Time:** 60–75 minutes

Before you meet. Read Judges 16 twice, pen in hand. Mark the vow, the three lies, "he did not know," the prayer, and the burial. Read Judges 13–15, Hebrews 11:32, and John 2:19–22.

OPEN (5 MINUTES)

Pray. Read Judges 16:4–22 aloud. Ask: "What did Samson see clearly—and what did he not see?"

OBSERVE (15 MINUTES)

1. **The gift and the vow.** What was Samson's calling (Judges 13:5)? What was the Nazirite sign (Numbers 6)? Where does his strength come from (13:25; 14:6; 15:14)?
2. **The secret.** Why does Samson keep playing Delilah's game (16:6–14)? What does he finally tell her (16:17)? What is the difference between the sign and the source?

INTERPRET (20 MINUTES)

3. **The night he did not know.** What does "as at other times" reveal about Samson (16:20)? Why is "he did not know that the LORD had left him" so frightening? What does this verse not mean?
4. **The prayer in the dark.** Read 16:23–30 slowly. Why does God answer a prayer for revenge? What is faithful and what is dangerous in it? How should we pray?
5. **The burial and the record.** What does "he had judged Israel twenty years" say about the gift and the waste (16:31)? Why is Samson in Hebrews 11:32?

APPLY (20 MINUTES)

6. **The sign and the source.** Where are we tempted to trust the sign—ministry, knowledge, reputation—while neglecting the source? Give one example.
7. **The eyes.** Where have you stopped seeing your own patterns? Who has been telling you the truth, and how have you responded?
8. **The small prayer.** What would it look like to pray "Remember me" this week—not a polished prayer, just an honest one? Who could you ask to pray with you?

CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

Invite each person to write one sentence: "The sign I am trusting is ____. The source I need is ____." No one has to report it.

Pray: "Lord Jesus, you are the true temple. You let your body be broken to put us back together. Forgive us for trusting the sign instead of the source. Open our eyes to see ourselves and to see you. Remember us, not because we are strong, but because you are faithful. Make us a church where the strong can be honest and the broken can be found. Amen."

Remind them: the invitation is not "be strong enough to be remembered." It is "come to the One who remembers."

LEADER NOTES

- **The gift and the vow.** The Spirit is the source; the hair is the sign. Samson violates the corpse rule (14:8–9) and attends a drinking feast (14:10); the text does not say he drank. Keep the focus on the source.
- **The secret.** Delilah is not called a prostitute; the woman in Gaza is. Her motives are money and allegiance. Do not make her the sole villain or shame people with a sexual past. Samson's choices are the focus.
- **The night he did not know.** Judges 16:20 describes the withdrawal of the Spirit's empowering presence for Samson's calling, not the loss of salvation. Warn against activity without intimacy.
- **The prayer in the dark.** The prayer is mixed: covenant faith and revenge. God's answer is grace and providence, not an endorsement of revenge. Do not celebrate the killing or Samson's death. If anyone discloses suicidal thoughts, follow safeguarding and provide crisis resources immediately.
- **The burial and the record.** Samson is named among the faithful as grace, not approval. Hold warning and hope together.
- **The gospel.** John 2:19–22 is the key: Jesus' body is the temple destroyed and raised. The contrast is intentional but not a one-to-one allegory. End with 2 Corinthians 12:9—strength in weakness.
- **Care.** If anyone discloses abuse or self-harm, follow safeguarding and connect them to pastoral and professional care.